

1887



A crest belonging to Czar Ferdinand I, who was elected ruler of Bulgaria.

BULGARIA HAD BEEN CAUGHT UP

in the wave of nationalism that swept through Europe in the earlier part of the 19th century (see 1848). Bulgaria's independence struggle—during which 15,000 Bulgarians were massacred by Turkish troops in 1876—had attracted Europe's attention. A couple of years later a small Bulgarian principality was established and Britain and Austria-Hungary ensured Russia would not have influence there. By 1885, Bulgaria had merged with **Eastern Rumelia**, and after a coup d'état, the two states were unified. This altered the Balkan balance of power and Serbia declared war. The conflict was brief and peace was restored by 1886. On July 1887, **Prince Ferdinand** of Saxe-Coburg-Gotha (1861–1948) was elected ruler of Bulgaria.



Czar Ferdinand I

Postage stamp, with Czar Ferdinand. He was elected to the position after political infighting led Bulgarians to look further afield for a leader.

1888



An engraving depicts slaves washing diamonds at a Brazilian mine.

720,000

BRAZILIAN

200,000

CUBAN

Slave population

At the time of their respective abolitions, Brazil and Cuba had large slave populations. Freedom was initially slow in coming to slaves.

BRAZIL, LIKE CUBA, CONTINUED

TO MAKE USE OF SLAVES much later than other former colonies. In South America, the republics that emerged from the Spanish Empire had abolished slavery by the middle of the century. And like Spain, **Brazil** had been put under pressure by the British to end the trade, which eventually occurred in 1850. Over the next thirty years, growing **abolitionist sentiment** reached the highest level, as the emperor **Dom Pedro II** (1825–91) became sympathetic to these ideas. He was interested in the gradual abolition of slavery but was aware of the dangers of a slaveholder backlash. He had observed not only what had happened in Cuba, but also in the US Civil War (see 1861). In 1871, a gradualist measure known as the **Rio Branco Law**, which freed children born to slave mothers, was enacted. Later measures in 1885 freed slaves who were older than 65. Eventually, a **proclamation in May 1888** completely abolished slavery.

1889

“IF THERE BE A **GOD**, I THINK THAT WHAT HE **WOULD LIKE ME TO DO** IS **PAINT** AS MUCH OF **THE MAP OF AFRICA BRITISH RED** AS POSSIBLE...”

Cecil Rhodes, British politician, on colonization

IN PARIS, ENGINEER GUSTAVE

EIFFEL (1832–1923) DAZZLED the city and all of Europe with his **tower**, which was opened to the public on March 31. Eiffel won a design contest to build the tower as part of the **International Exposition** of 1889 in honor of the centenary of the French Revolution. With its 984-ft (300-m) tower—twice the height of the Great Pyramid in Giza—nothing like it had ever been seen. The tower attracted almost two million visitors in the first six months after it opened.

Brazil, meanwhile, faced political upheaval as a military coup overthrew leader **Dom Pedro II**. The military, clergy, and aristocracy had been angered by



Eiffel Tower

Initially criticized by the Parisian public who thought it unsightly, the tower has come to be an iconic Parisian landmark.

IMPERIALISM

The late 19th century was a time of extensive colonial rule by European powers. “The Rhodes Colossus” (right) from an 1892 *Punch* magazine depicts British colonizer, Cecil Rhodes, straddling the continent after the announcement of his proposed telegraph line from Cape Town to Cairo. But this was also a period infamous for European exploitation of natural resources, as well as the indifferent or cruel treatment of native peoples.



some of Pedro's reforms and, although still popular with the public, he abdicated and a republic was declared.

Farther north, in Panama, the canal project (see 1880) had collapsed, and work on it came to a halt. The **Compagnie Universelle du Canal Interocéanique** and the French public had lost faith in the enterprise as the death toll mounted and construction was plagued by endless problems.

In Africa, British rule was expanding apace as **Cecil John Rhodes** (1853–1902)—who had already established his reputation in the gold and diamond mines in South Africa—received a charter for his **British South Africa Company** in 1889. The company was expected to respect local law and beliefs. However, Rhodes's

aim was to acquire territory in Southern Africa and continue the extraction of valuable minerals. Rhodes came to symbolize the excesses of **colonial greed**.

22,000
THE NUMBER
OF WORKERS
WHO DIED
DURING
A FAILED
ATTEMPT
TO BUILD
THE PANAMA
CANAL

January 24 Battle of Dogali: Italians defeated by Ethiopia
First automatic rifle, the **Mondragon**, patented by General Manuel Mondragon (1880–1914)
March 4 Gottlieb Daimler (1834–1900) reveals his first automobile
November 8 Emile Berliner (1851–1929) patents gramophone
November 13 Bloody Sunday—violent clash between Irish protesters and police in London

“Jack the Ripper” murders occur in London
Slavery abolished in Brazil
June 15 Wilhelm II becomes German emperor
Kodak snapshot camera becomes available to the public
Earliest known recording of classical music made on a wax cylinder

March 9 Yohannes IV of Ethiopia killed by Sudanese forces at Battle of Metemma
March 31 Eiffel Tower completed and opens

Ivory Coast becomes French protectorate, later becomes colony
Dutch artist **Vincent van Gogh** (1853–90) commits himself to a hospital after mutilating own ear

China's first imperial railroad extends all the way from Tangshan to Tianjin
Italy occupies **Eritrea**, in Horn of Africa

November 14 American journalist **Nellie Bly** begins her successful attempt to travel around world in less than 80 days
November 15 Military coup deposes **Pedro II** of Brazil and abolishes monarchy